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Dado: A Form of Cooperation on Equal Terms among the Macha Oromo of Ethiopia

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0. Introduction

The most important forms of traditional¹ cooperation among Macha farmers are *dabo* and *dado*.

The former is a one day's cooperation between 10–40 people, or even more, convened by a man who needs their help in e. g. ploughing and sowing, reaping, clearing, the making of a road, the building of a house, and the like. I have dealt with this form of cooperation extensively in an earlier article (BARTELS 1975).

The latter, dealt with in this paper, is a form of long-term reciprocal cooperation on equal terms between a smaller number of people who work in turn for each other.

The research concerned was carried out in the field, during 1974, among the Macha Oromo living in the vicinity of the small town of Dembidollo in south-western Ethiopia (ca. 8°30'N, 35°E)².

¹ The words 'tradition' and 'traditional' mostly refer to the situation as it was at the time of the Amharic conquest (1888). For the rest I am far from suggesting that this situation was a static one.

² Since the Ethiopian revolution the Galla prefer to be called by the name they give themselves 'Oromo'.

My special thanks go to the Institute of Ethiopian Studies, Addis Ababa, to my Macha assistants Asafa Disasa and Ensermu Waquma and their parents, and to my faithful informant Shagerdi Buqo. I am indebted to Dr. P. T. W. Baxter for several useful comments on this paper, and to Sister Elizabeth Armstrong for her help with regard to the English text.

Concerning the underlying cultural values I refer the reader to the first section of my previous article about *dabo*. This section deals with: Cattle and crops; Social organization; Honour; Conception of man; Life and death; The suprahuman.

1. Some notes with regard to Macha cooperation in general

1.1. In their hilly country the Macha speak of so called *biya*. A *biya* is a rather limited area, marked by little streams, valleys and hills. Normally a *biya* comprises several neighbourhoods or groups of houses. Probably the best criterion for demarking a neighbourhood is that its people have their morning coffee together in each other's house in turn. Such a neighbourhood rarely exceeds ten houses. In their traditional forms of cooperation several neighbourhoods, or even *biya*, may be involved.

1.2. Since the conquest by the Ethiopian emperor (1888) and the establishment of the *pax amharica* in Machaland, the clans have grown less and less localized, to the extent that, sometimes, one cannot speak of a dominant local clan anymore, even within a *biya*. Though in many respects they still think in terms of kinship, in fact good relations with neighbours, achieved status, and friendship play an important part in matters of cooperation.

1.3. Help is given and received primarily on the basis of a person's belonging to a certain group within Macha society. In other words: it is given and received primarily according to the ties which link people socially: ties of blood, affinity, servitude or neighbourhood. The moral norms ruling their cooperation run parallelly with the foregoing. Duties and rights are primarily based on a person's social status and not on his need as an individual human being.

1.4. Formerly, craftsmen like the *tumtu* (blacksmiths, weavers, potters) and *faqi* (tanners) would not participate in the work with the 'real Oromo', for all their being part of Macha society. However, for a long time, both of them have worked together with the higher social groups and they have even stopped eating separately. But still the cups and plates used by tanners are cleaned secretly with the bitter leaves of the *ebicha* tree. So it is in this area. In more remote areas, however, the separation between these craftsmen and the 'real Oromo' is still maintained.

1.5. People of other ethnic groups such as the Yambo (Anuak), Mao and others (often descendants of slaves) are not prevented from participating in the work. As one informant put it: "They did this work before, when they were still slaves."

1.6. All traditional forms of cooperation are characterized by the absence of payment in cash. The reward consists in receiving similar help from the other party, food and drink, or both. Where it is impossible to reward the participants by similar help the reward in food and drink ought to be more generous. Such is the case e. g. with the *dabo*, where many poorer people work for a more well-to-do farmer. Since it is unlikely that most of these participants would convene a *dabo* for themselves, the meal becomes a real feast-meal. We will see that with the *dado* things are different. Here all members profit in turn from each others work. So the meal is kept simple.

1.7. All participants are supposed to take their tools with them.

1.8. Generally speaking, we can say that in this area everybody can cooperate with everyone else in farmwork, provided his share in the work is suited to his sex and physical strength.

1.9. No Macha feels happy if he has to go to the market alone, to eat alone or to sleep alone. Loneliness is the beginning of death; it is at variance with the normal human condition. It is also dangerous. A lonely person is pitied by all. If he stays apart of his own will, he is quickly distrusted. Hence, being together, working together constitutes to them a value of its own, irrespective of its output in terms of achievement.

2. Main characteristics of the *dado*

2.1. Not being a linguist I refrain from speculating too much about the etymology of the word *dado*. Oromo language knows words like *dada*, concord, union, agreement, and *dadesu*, to agree (see LA THIENE's dictionary), but in my area these words are not of common occurrence. On the other hand people do use the same word '*dado*' in certain expressions like: "*Waqni dadosa ha-debisu* – May *Waq* (Sky/God) repay him (good with good or evil with evil)" and: "*Wogga lama dura bilako of wan fudate, animo amma dadosa'n debise* – Two years ago he took away my chopper, now I have given him tit for tat."

So the name of this form of cooperation seems to be connected with its being an agreement for mutual help on equal terms.

As with *dabo* the word *dado* is used for both the work and the group of people involved.

2.2. The *dado* group works in turn for each of its members.

Dado means turning around in rotation. It is similar to what herdsmen do during the night: they take turns in keeping watch near the cattle [Shagerdi Buqo].

2.3. The member whose turn it is, can have the whole group work for an outsider. If such an outsider gives a compensation, this compensation goes wholly to the member 'whose day it is'.

2.4. It is a cooperation on equal terms. A girl of 14 years has the same rights as her *dado* companion of 50. If there are three sisters in the same *dado*, each of them gets her turn.

2.5. The number of the people involved is always rather limited. It rarely exceeds 8 or 10.

2.6. It is a long-term cooperation. A *dado* may last for months.

People often start a *dado* as soon as the first rains fall. Since it is still very hot at that time, they usually work for some hours in the morning or in the afternoon. Such a way of working is called *dakubute*. But after some time, when the sun grows less hot, they will start working for whole days [Ensermu Waquma].

2.7. The order of turns (*tara*) is fixed in an informal way (there are no rules of precedence), and can be changed by mutual agreement. But all members take their turn in strict rotation. A new member who joins the *dado* in the course of time, has first to work for all the others before he gets his turn.

2.8. A member who turns up much too late for the work, has to make up for it by working longer if circumstances permit, or by being content that the others repay him in the same way.

2.9. If one of the members falls sick, he loses his turn in the *dado*. In other words, a *dado* group as such never works gratuitously for one of its members, even if he was legitimately excused from coming. But if such a person has worked for two of his companions in the current cycle, these two will have to repay him his work in kind. If they fail to do so, that person is for one turn dispensed from working for them. It is against the *dado*'s character that the members abandon their rights in the slightest degree. A member who is prevented from coming, however, can send another in his place.

2.10. If rain makes work impossible, the *dado* work is postponed. If it is raining only part of the working time, the lost hours are made up.

2.11. The member who has his turn, has to provide his companions with food and drink. But these don't need to be more than their ordinary meal. So the drink is normally coffee with salt, sometimes some buttermilk, but never beer. As for the food, there is always *mullu* (cooked maize, barley, weath and pulse) and *akayi* (roasted grains or pulse). There are two kinds of this *akayi*: *danfisa* and *onsoso*. The first is obtained when the pulse and grains before being lightly roasted, are put in hot water. The latter is prepared without this process of softening. Sorghum is always served as *onsoso*.

2.12. A day's work normally starts at nine or half past nine in the morning. After noon there is a pause for eating and drinking.

2.13. The cycle of a *dado* can be interrupted for several reasons: an accident or death in the members' families, sickness, or a mutual agreement to profit from an occasion to join day labour, and the like. When a *dado* group joins as a whole into work for individual payment, this is not considered as *dado* work.

2.14. Among married people the proposals for a *dado* are usually made while the neighbours have their morning coffee together. Traditionally boys and girls don't share this coffee.

While drinking his morning coffee with his neighbours, a man can say: "Please, come to work tomorrow with me in the *dado*." He tells them the kind of work that has to be done. If he does not find enough people who are interested in forming a *dado* with him, he will ask people outside his neighbourhood. But often he will not need to ask them at all, since, after the coffee party, the rumor of his proposal will spread fast. People will come to him to ask if they can join his *dado* [Ensermu Waquma].

Since boys can move freely everywhere, it is easy for them to form a *dado*. As for the girls, they will ask each other on the occasions at which they can meet e. g. while collecting firewood together, or while going to the river for water.

2.15. Normally a *dado* is dissolved when there is no work left to be done, or when the members start working elsewhere. Sometimes, too, a *dado* may be dissolved as a result of quarrelling. But mostly such quarrels are ended by making peace or by a member leaving the group.

2.16. Various *dado* groups and their work:

a) Girls only:

Work: weeding, breaking the earth-clumps after the men have ploughed, harvesting, collecting firewood, and the like.

b) Boys only:

Except for collecting firewood which is an exclusively woman's business, their work can be: weeding, harvesting, planting coffee, the clearing of coffee plots, collecting bamboo stems and long grass for housebuilding, making fences, the cutting of smaller trees and the splitting of their stems, digging up grass clumps, removing heavy stones, and the like.

c) Married men only:

Besides the work done by boys theirs is the heavier work like cutting big trees and removing very heavy stones, digging up tree trunks, and any work that entails danger.

d) Married women only:

They hardly ever form a *dado* of their own. If so, their work is the same as the girls'.

e) Mixed groups:

Boys can form a *dado* together with girls, when some harder work is to be done. Both of them can join married people. Women and men often work together. In fact many *dado* groups are mixed. But whether the *dado* people are young or old, men or women, all are on equal terms.

Occasionally *dado* groups may cooperate with each other ³.

³ For a few years, people also know what they call 'a new form of *dado*', the *quqube*. It was imported from elsewhere. A certain number of them (mostly youths) agree

3. Good company

3.1. We have mentioned already the Macha's need of togetherness in general. Being together, feeling themselves part of a group, is to them a necessity of life. In this respect they are very sensitive, indeed, to each others' needs.

People who prove able to enhance this feeling of togetherness by preventing quarrels, by singing and joking, by story telling, are appreciated always and everywhere.

They also go to great lengths in accepting old and weak people into their *dado* for the sake of ties of affinity, blood or neighbourhood. As an old man phrased it:

Dado means helping each other. In a *dado* the strong and the weak help each other.

In addition, such a weaker companion can make up amply for his handicap as a worker by being a pleasant character or a good singer. Certainly he is more readily asked to participate than a good worker with a quarrelsome temperament.

The *dado*'s quality as a long-term cooperation also makes the choice of good companions important. But such a good choice is made easy by the limited number of participants, by the fact that they can start with three and end up with eight, and by the possibility of extending the time taken for the work.

All these things impart to the *dado* a very important feature: the possibility of forming and maintaining a socially homogenous group, a group of so called *hiriya*, which from the standpoint of good company is always the most preferable.

by written contract to work in turn for each other. They choose a leader who keeps their contract. The rules are as follows: 1. Only good workers can participate. 2. They work strictly by the clock. "At *quqube* you need a watch." 3. Any infringement with regard to the working time or to the achievement is punished with a fine. 4. The member who's day it is, has to provide the group with coffee or tea and good bread. 5. When they work for an outsider, this man has to pay one dollar for every worker a day. This money is used by the leader for buying a fixed amount of really good beer, which is divided among the members and taken home by them, so that they can either drink or sell it. 6. If the leader or the man-of-the-day fail in providing the amount of food and drink required, or if its quality leaves anything to be desired, they are fined. 7. All fines are used to buy different beer which is consumed together. 8. The order of turns is fixed by lot. Under the influence of this *quqube*, people will sometimes cast lots where a traditional *dado* is concerned. This, however, and also the other rigid rules of the *quqube* is felt to be alien to their own way of cooperation. Accordingly, the older people do not like to work in such a *quqube*. – Day labour for payment in cash is normal nowadays. So it may happen that an outsider pays a *dado* group in cash. In such cases the sum goes to the member whose day it is. If the *dado* group should accept individual payment, the work is not counted as *dado* work.

3.2. The word '*hiriya*', within context, is best translated by 'companion' or 'comrade' ⁴. It implies first of all a person's belonging to the same social group as another person. In former times, when their *gada* system was still alive, all the members of the same *gada* class used to call each other *hiriya*, regardless of their being young children or old men. So much so that a young boy could participate in the meetings of his *gada* class on equal terms with grey haired men.

Nowadays the situation is roughly as follows:

a) All married women are *hiriya* to each other, regardless of their age. There are no barriers between them in daily intercourse, speech, songs, ritual ⁵.

b) Unmarried girls from menstruation time onwards consider each other likewise as *hiriya*.

c) Another *hiriya* group is formed by the older men. The line of division runs between 35 and 40 years of age.

d) Younger married men also are *hiriya* to each other. The cleavage between them and older married men is so great that they will rather associate in certain circumstances and aspects with older youths than with the former.

e) Boys around 16 and older youths form a fifth *hiriya* group.

f) A sixth group, less strongly marked, is formed by boys between 13 and 16.

All these are, so to say, perfect *hiriya* groups. In practice, however, older youths and younger married men often go together, and the same holds good for older girls and married women. To all of them Ensermu Waquma's words apply:

A *hiriya* group is always best. They can joke, play, talk, laugh and sing as much as they like. They do not need to be ashamed of each other.

3.3. People who are not in peace with each other and who, therefore, do not eat and drink together, will never join the same *dado*. To a somewhat lesser degree the same holds good for people who are liable to quarrel with each other.

Two girls who are in love with the same boy do better not to join the same *dado*, nor two boys who are in love with the same girl [a mother].

3.4. A quarrelsome member can be expelled from the group by the others. To this effect they have only to refuse to work for him anymore.

⁴ The word '*hiriya*' is sometimes carelessly translated by 'age mates'. I myself made this mistake in my article about the *dabo* (BARTELS 1975: 897).

⁵ I find myself in agreement with EDMUND LEACH (s. a.: 403) where he classes two kinds of behaviour as 'ritual'. 1. Behaviour which forms part of a signalling system and which serves to 'communicate information', not because of any mechanical link between means and ends, but because of the existence of a culturally defined code. 2. Behaviour which is potent in terms of the cultural conventions of the actors but not potent in a rational – technical sense (i. e. which judged by our standards of verification, produces observable results in a strict mechanical way), or alternatively behaviour which is directed towards evoking the potency of occult powers even though it is not presumed to be potent by itself.

3.5. For both younger boys and girls their parents have a say concerning the choice of their companions. “*Hiriya gadden nama balesa* – Man is deprived by bad companions”, people say, or “*Fardi harre wajin ole dūfu barra* – A horse that associates with donkeys learns to fart.” When boys or girls are quarreling, their respective parents may interfere. The former may be urged to make peace by a handshake, the latter by kissing each other. A saying on such occasions is: “*Waqayo jedati ha-hafu* – For the sake of *Waq* drop the matter.”

Sometimes, also a boy or a girl is forced by his or her parents to leave a *dado* group, e. g., when the parents are informed that their child is using the *dado* for a love affair that they do not approve.

4. Singing during the *dado* work

4.1. The Macha’s repertory of songs remains impressive, despite the impact of Amharic culture and the rather strong social change, especially after world war II. It comprises love songs, fighting songs, praise songs for their cattle and grain, triumph songs for killers of big game, praise songs in their honour, insult songs at the address of their friends’ wedding partners (who are always of another clan), goodbye songs of girls for their friend who is about to marry, a. s. o.

4.2. All these songs can be sung at their work in the field, though in fact some of them are hardly ever heard outside their ritual context.

4.3. There are no songs ritually connected with certain kinds of farmwork or with work in general. So it is in my area anyway. I never heard of harvesting or sowing songs and the like. We will return to this later (see appendix).

4.4. This does not mean that in any group any song is permitted, be it by the group as a whole or by one single member of it. The golden rule is that the songs should amuse everyone in the group and hurt no one. The more the group is socially homogenous the greater the range of choice available.

4.5. Generally speaking the songs reserved to perfectly homogenous groups i. e. groups of *hiriya*, are of two kinds:

a) Songs which contain what the Macha call *dubbi yelo*, shameful words. These are words or expressions which openly or covertly refer directly to the sexual organs or to acts directly connected with the sex act. The rule that such songs can be sung only by *hiriya* has to be understood in the strictest sense. This means that e. g. though boys and married men have the same *hiriya* songs of this kind, they cannot sing them while working together.

b) Songs in which other social groups are insulted, threatened or ridiculed. E. g. while working with married men, boys cannot sing songs in which they boast of having access to married women. If one of the *hiriya* is a blacksmith, any song in which these craftsmen are derided, has to be avoided.

4.6. Outsiders who are liable to be insulted by the songs of a *dado* group, are supposed to keep aloof in order not to hamper them. On the other hand, a *dado* group must check itself in case such an outsider clearly cannot keep his distance, e. g. an old woman going to the clinic who would have much trouble in making a detour.

4.7. Most *hiriya* songs have their ritual context in the people's social life. We mentioned already hunting songs and insult songs. For all that they are stripped of their ritual context while they are sung by a *dado* group, their being sung in this circumstance retains some value for the rites and, of course for the values included in them. By singing them people train themselves for these rites. This aspect is of special importance to the girls who are carefully looked after, and don't get many opportunities of meeting each other. It is almost exclusively in their *dado* groups that they can train themselves for the rites in which they have to sing as a group. As a result the girls sing more than others at their *dado* work.

4.8. Love, war and praise songs (including the triumph songs of killers) are most suited for mixed groups. But shameful words and an occasional derision of other social groups which may occur in these songs, have to be left out.

4.9. With regard to the songs' poetical structure and their performance the following may suffice here. (For a more comprehensive explanation see my article about *dabo*, 1975: especially 898 note 5.) The shorter love songs (rarely more than 8 verses) have no chorus. One good singer may sing four or five such songs one after another, though it is felt to be better, if the singers are eager to follow each other. Mostly one song inspires another which then turns out to have something in common with its predecessor. In this way songs with the same theme, e. g. unrequited love, or with similar imagery, are found grouped together.

All other songs, however, have a chorus. More often than not, a soloist can make a choice out of several choruses. When he reaches the end of his stanza, the length of which also depends on his inspiration of the moment, he will anticipate the chorus in whole or in part, after which the others join in. The soloist's texts are not fixed. He makes a choice among existing sets of verses, and sometimes, inserts a new set of his own. It may happen that the soloist digresses from the main theme of the song, e. g. by inserting a love song into a fighting song (if the poetic structure allows for it), but this does not change the character of the songs in the people's eyes. To them it is the chorus which determines the song's quality. In other words, first of all what is sung by all of them is of importance, not so much the soloist's performance. To them the chorus is not so much an affirmation of the stanza as the reverse. This sheds a light of its own on the fact that individual love songs have no chorus.

4.10. Sometimes singing has to be omitted during the work. Such is the case when somebody of the area where the work is done, has died. For a little child the time of mourning may be 2–3 days; for an adult person 2–3 weeks.

4.11. People are not always found singing at their work. The area to the west of Dembidollo where this research was carried out, contrasts unfavourably with other areas of Machaland in this regard. It is the boys and girls who sing most.

5. *Dado* groups and their songs

Only the well used songs are given here:

5.1. Girls only

5.1.1. Songs connected with marriage. – According to traditional Macha custom in this area, every couple was first betrothed in the house of the girl's father. After a rather long time, the wedding-day was agreed. During the weeks preceding this day, the bride's friends would sing in her house goodbye songs (a). The boy would go to his girl's house on the eve of the wedding-day, accompanied by his go-betweens. He was met by insult songs, sung by the same girls (b). After the bride-price had been handed over (this always contained a dress for the bride's mother), the bride would sing with her companions and the women the so called 'song of the dress' (c). The next day, the boy would take his bride home with the help of his *minje*. This *minje* was the man he had chosen himself to be his bride's protector and advisor during her married life in respect to troubles with her husband and her in-laws. Besides this *minje* a number of youths, friends of the groom, would accompany them, singing. While entering her in-laws' compound, the bride was met in her turn by the insult songs sung by girls of the groom's family and of the neighbourhood (d). The wedding ritual now took place at which a sheep was killed as a symbol of the 'killing' of the bride, who, being a virgin, shed her maiden blood. The next day, the *minje* would bring the little piece of cloth with the maiden blood to the girl's parents. There he was welcomed with the praise song in his honour, the 'song of the *minje*'s saltbar' (e) ⁶. All these songs are part of the repertory of any *dado* group consisting of girls only.

⁶ Nowadays, nearly all marriages have departed from this traditional scheme. Whether an official engagement has taken place or not, the girl escapes from her parents' house to join her fiancé, who deflowers her in the house of a friend. The girl sends word to her parents that her escape and defloration were voluntary, and informs them about the bride price agreed upon between herself and the boy. After a simplified wedding-feast has been celebrated without songs (it is officially a secret wedding) the boy, after some time, takes at least part of the bride price to his parents-in-law's house, without, however, entering (he keeps himself hidden nearby). After some weeks the girl's parents invite the *minje* for the *misrachu* ceremony, at which he shows them their daughter's maiden blood. He is welcomed by praise songs in his honour, and collects money for the girl. After a year or so, *mulachu* takes place, on which occasion the boy, accompanied by his wife and her *minje*, pays a visit to his parents-in-law and makes peace with them. It is on this occasion that he is met by the insult songs. He delivers the remainder of the bride price (or the main part of it) after which peace is made. It is also on this occasion that the girl with her friends will sing the 'song of the dress' for her mother, and that her friends sing the goodbye songs which they could not sing before. In this way all

a) Goodbye songs for the bride-to-be, *wedu sena*. – The themes are:

1. Her separation from her friends, the singing girls, and the end of her happy girlhood.

2. The cruelty of her parents and brothers who 'sell' their daughter and sister for the sake of the bride price.

3. Fear of the unknown environment she is about to enter: another clan, in-laws unknown to her, another house and another neighbourhood, – in short a milieu which is indifferent, critical, even hostile to her, and where she will have to start anew to assure herself of sympathy and respect.

4. Good advice with regard to her behaviour as a married woman.

These songs always contain hard words addressed to the girl's parents and to her brothers who profit from her bride price for their own marriage. It was in view of these songs and others of the kind that Shagerdi Buqo, my best informant, remarked:

When their daughter's *dado* group is working near the house, the parents of that girl would take care to be absent.

Indeed, they must only listen to these songs in the ritual context of her wedding-day.

b) Insult songs addressed to the groom, *wedu arabsa gurba*. – The themes are:

1. He is physically ugly and dirty.

2. He has all kinds of diseases, especially venereal ones.

3. His clan and his family are inferior.

4. He did not pay enough.

5. All his fine clothes are borrowed.

6. He is not a killer of big game.

c) Song of the dress, *wedu uwissa*. – The main theme is that the girl's mother has received such a fine dress from the groom. Accordingly, this theme is touched on in the chorus. But in the stanzas all the themes of the songs *a* and *b* can be touched on with now and then a special reference to the dress. The mother is always accused of 'selling' her daughter for the sake of this dress; How much will she regret this exchange! It must be noticed, however, that the girl herself will never address an insulting word to her parents.

d) Insult songs addressed to the bride, *wedu arabsa durba*. – The themes are:

1. She is a goat, showing her sexual organs to everybody and mating everywhere.

2. She has all kind of diseases, especially venereal ones.

traditional wedding songs are sung except for the insult songs addressed to the bride when she enters her in-law's compound. Since this latter song is only rarely sung at present (it is only sung if the marriage progresses in the traditional way), it is also tending to disappear from the repertory of the *dado* groups.

As long as a girl's wedding ritual has not been completed, including the peace making and her visit to her parents, she is not considered as belonging to the social group of married women. And so is the boy with regard of the group of married men. So both of them continue to be insulted by the respective *dado* groups.

3. She is not a virgin and cheats her groom who will be disappointed for having bought a woman instead of a girl.

4. Her breasts are dried up already.

5. She is proud and coquettish.

e) Praise song of the *minje*, *wedu sogida minje*. – The Macha name of this song means: song of the *minje*'s saltbar. For the *minje* has to give a saltbar to the bride. The themes are the same as in songs *a* and *b*, with this addition that the *minje* is praised as the only person in the bride's new environment who guarantees protection and sympathy. It is he who will 'dry her tears'. The chorus refers to the *minje*'s tasty and sound saltbar, a symbol ⁷ of the giver himself.

In all the songs mentioned we are confronted with institutionalized insult and praise. The people addressed are seen only as representatives of their social group. So nobody cares whether the insults are justified or not with regard to them personally.

Whilst in the songs *a*, *c* and *e* insult is only one of the themes dealt with in the stanzas, the insult songs display nothing but scolding.

There are always girls and boys in an area who are engaged. Sometimes, such a girl was or still is a member of the singers' *dado*. The fiancées of their brothers and cousins are insulted and mentioned by name, and so are the boys of all their girl friends. So one can say that, as soon as a boy or girl is engaged, they appear in the repertory of the girls' *dados*, either in their own area or in the area of their partners.

5.1.2. Songs connected with hunting. – Another set of girls' songs have their ritual context in hunting rites. As soon as a killer returns from the wilderness with his trophies (e. g. the head and tail of a wild buffalo), he is received with songs. The girls' contribution is called 'praise song of a killer' (*f*). Later the hunter will have to make peace with his victim's clan (other buffaloes) and their tutelary spirit. At this peacemaking ritual the girls will also sing another song, the 'song of the undercut', a piece of meat to be found below the spine (*g*). At this ritual a sheep's undercut is hung in an acacia tree, planted near the killer's house. Men and youths who are eager to set out hunting, pass around this tree, dancing and shouting. While doing so, they try to pull down the undercut with their spears. The one who succeeds in doing so, has to set out immediately. During this performance the girls sing this 'song of the undercut'.

f) Praise song of a killer, *farsa ajesa*. – The themes are: the prowess of the killers and the cowardliness of those who stay at home and behave like girls.

⁷ By 'symbol' I understand the same as V. W. TURNER: "It must not be forgotten that ritual symbols are not merely signs representing known things; they are felt to possess ritual efficacy, to be charged with power from unknown sources, and to be capable of acting on persons or groups coming into contact with them in such a way as to change them for the better or in a desired direction" (1967: 54).

g) The song of the undercut, *wedu lukke*. – The themes are the same as in song *f*. In the chorus the girls sing: “Who will pull down the undercut?”

While singing these songs, *f* and *g*, the girls mention quite a few names of men and boys. In former times, these songs of the girls and the personal insults contained in them were a permanent exhortation to the boys to set out to kill big game. Nowadays, this quality of being a killer is partly replaced by other marks of status, but still quite a few girls are pleased if their groom is a killer, even if he also enjoys other status symbols.

Songs *a-g* are all of them *hiriya* songs. They are made and sung by girls only.

5.1.3. Such is not the case with the short love songs they sing sometimes at their *dado* work (*h*). Girls are not supposed to compose love songs themselves. It is regarded as being against their social status which, at least traditionally, means that they leave the choice of their husbands to their fathers. They can sing, however, other love songs made by men or boys, provided the persons concerned remain vague, so that the girls can make them their own.

h) Love songs, *wedu jalala*.

The themes are those common to all love songs: 1. unrequited love; 2. the impossibility of meeting the beloved one; 3. the impossibility of marrying because of difference in social standing; 4. the good qualities of the lover.

5.2. Married women only. – When some married women form a *dado*, whether or not together with some older girls, they may sing:

a) Birth songs, *wedu daa*. – The ritual context of these songs is the birth of a child. The songs are sung then

1. immediately after giving birth
2. on the second or third day after
3. on the fifth day
4. on the ninth day.

The singers are neighbour women. The themes are:

1. the galantry of the woman who braves the hardships of married life and childbearing in order to have a family;
2. thanksgiving to *Maram* (or *Atete*), the female deity (*ayana*) who gave a child to this woman, and helped her in giving birth;
3. the happiness of being a mother, contrasted with the pitiful fate of a barren woman.

b) *Atete* (*Maram*) songs. – Their ritual context is a rite in honour of this deity of female fertility, performed in favour of a neighbour woman who longs for a child.

The themes are the same as those of the birth songs. Here, however, less is said about the honour and happiness of motherhood and more about the lamentable situation of a barren woman who failed to attain a respected place in her husband's clan, who runs the risk of seeing her husband take a second wife, and who has no child to take care of her in her old age.

(In these *Atete* rites other deities are often invoked, deities of ethnic groups from whom the Macha in this area took their wives or concubines. But as far as I know, these songs are never sung after childbirth or during work.)

c) Love songs. – We must keep in mind here, that, formerly, having lovers was normal to both men and women. Indeed, the pre-christian Macha way of life did not include prostitutes. Tenderness between husband and wife was frowned upon as very risky, and love was looked for outside marriage by both partners. Boys were supposed to find their own way to married women (girls were not available to them, since they had to remain virgin). Love songs dealing with adultery were sung among *hiriya* for pleasure's sake, and, in ritual context, every eight year for a short period in the frame of the *gada* rites, when even husbands and wives were obliged to insult each other by shameful songs. But for the last forty years, no *gada* rites have taken place, and social changes in various field (among other things a host of prostitutes in trading centres and the influence of christian missions) have robbed these old customs of much of their prestige. Nowadays, the women may still sing love songs at their work, but they normally abstain from love songs which overtly deal with adultery.

5.3. Married men only:

a) Love songs. – In contrast to women, married men still like to sing songs dealing with more or less humorous adventures of lovers who seek to obtain access to married women. But most of their repertory of love songs deals with other types of songs in which adultery is not openly lauded.

b) Hunting songs. – Here the triumph song of a killer of big game comes first. The themes are:

1. the ambition to become a killer;
2. the mockery of women and girls addressed to non killers, which urges them to set out;
3. the hardships of a stay in the wilderness;
4. failure to find the sought after game;
5. the circumstances of his killing and the fine qualities of his kill;
6. more success with women as a result of his being a killer;
7. the cowardliness of those who stay at home.

Those who never killed any big game can find in these songs plenty of verses to suit them when they want to sing of their eagerness to set out.

The ritual contexts of these songs are:

1. immediately after killing, when the killer mounts his kill and starts singing;
2. at the killer's homecoming;
3. at the ritual in which peace is made with the buffaloes' clan and its tutelary spirit.

While singing during work, i. e. outside these ritual contexts, a killer is expected not to elaborate too much on his own exploits.

c) War songs. – The themes are:

1. the cohesion of their own clan and its good qualities;
2. the pleasing sight of a group of warriors setting out to fight;
3. the cowardliness of certain clan-mates who prefer to stay at home and abuse the absence of the other warriors to lay with their wives;
4. the cowardliness of the enemy.

Several examples of these men's songs are to be found in my *dabo* paper.

5.4. Youths only:

a) Love songs. – At present boys are the great composers and singers of love songs. Some of them may deal with married women, but most songs are addressed to girls.

b) Hunting songs.

c) War songs.

5.5. Mixed groups

Except for the girls' songs, all songs mentioned can be sung by all participants or by some of them. But sets of verses which deride a social group represented among the workers, and all shameful words have to be avoided.

6. Appendix: Religious elements and views connected with farmwork

Even now it may happen that an older man, before cutting the first trees on untouched land, kills a sheep on the spot for that place's *ayana*⁸. His harvests depend on this *ayana*'s benevolence. Others say a short prayer just before ploughing and sowing, e. g. "*Ya Waqa, senyif lafa wol nū jalachisi* – O *Waqa* (God/sky) make seed and earth like each other on our behalf." But such kinds of prayers and rites are rather exceptional. More, even the most religious among my informants did not depict their grandfathers as praying more at their work than they themselves. Only one older man remarked at one time that maize's *ayana* likes the girls to sing at their work, and this man was not of my area. Shagerdi Buqo, my best informant, did not confirm his view. Anyhow, it would be wrong to conclude from such sayings and practices that the Macha consider their farmwork as an activity pleasing to God.

On the contrary: after several questions on my part about the matter Shagerdi Buqo, a very religious man, commented: "*Hojin ayana hinqabu* – farmwork has no *ayana*", a sentence which is probably best translated by: "Farmwork is not a religious activity."

⁸ There are two main concepts in the Macha interpretation of the supra-human: one is *Waqa* and the other *ayana*. *Waqa* means sky and/or God. *Ayana* is *Waqa* in a special way: it is *Waqa* in relation to particular events, persons and groups; it is *Waqa*'s creative power in a person, an animal, a plant, a clan or an animal species as a whole, making them the way they are. This particular aspect of *Waqa* is called that person's, that plant's, that animal's *ayana*.

Several other cultural elements point in the same direction.

1. There are no myths sacralizing farmwork, for all that it is indispensable to the Macha's subsistence.

2. If I am not mistaken in interpreting certain of their myths about the beginning of things, it was because of man's taking cultivation and procreation too much into his own hands, that *Waga* withdrew from him – a withdrawal resulting in a diminution of life on earth in all its forms.

3. The Macha's ritual head in the frame of their *gada* system, the *abba boqu* (holder of the staff), was forbidden to wound the earth by ploughing, to kill and to cut trees, together with other taboos which held good exclusively for him, like drinking from a broken cup or sitting on a broken chair. He has to behave as the ideal man. He is a symbol of the pure beginning.

4. The Macha are deeply convinced that peace with their fellow people is a *conditio sine qua non* to receive favours from *Waga* (God/sky). Accordingly, they consider such a peace indispensable before any ritual of some importance. However, while speaking about their communal work, they maintained unanimously that both ritual impurity by sex acts and quarrelling during the work did not affect the crops. Hence, when two girls do not join the same *dado* group because they are liable to quarrel with each other, this is done for reasons of good company only, and not out of fear that *Waga* will withdraw from the crops if they are quarrelling while weeding. People do not feel that their farmwork brings them nearer to *Waga* in a special way.

5. Pre-christian Macha society knew of two non working days a week: Friday for the *borana* (the highest social group) and Wednesday for the *gabaro*. The Ethiopian Church introduced the Saturday, later also the Sunday, and, in addition, a number of christian feastdays. Nowadays, some people have started working on a certain number of these feastdays under the influence of christian missions, and the Saturday has almost wholly disappeared as a non working day. But though Wednesday and Friday lost the quality of holidays they had in pre-christian times, one single element still endures. Ploughing and sowing, weeding and reaping are still left with regard to certain crops on Wednesday (by the *gabaro*) and on Friday (by the *borana*). So a working group which consists of both *borana* and *gabaro* will not do such work on Wednesday and Friday. The crops concerned are barley, wheat and maize. The reason given is that otherwise the insects will eat these crops, whether in the field or in the granaries. Working in a field of *daguja* or *tjef*, two crops which are not eaten by insects, is not forbidden, since it is evidently not punished by *Waga*.

6. Since Oromo culture has much in common with the Jewish one at early biblical times, a sidelong look at the Jewish view on work is justified here. In the Genesis myth, too, man takes his fate into his own hands. The woman is punished by an increase of pain in childbirth, and the man by the 'sweat of his brow' while tilling the earth.

In Macha view the two of them are connected: ploughing the earth is compared with sexual intercourse on the part of the man. *Niti akka lafati* – a woman is like the earth. Ploughing means 'wounding the earth' and sexual intercourse means 'killing' the woman.

Both of them are ambivalent. Both of them in practice contain elements *Waq* does not like. Both of them contain an element of punishment on *Waq*'s part.

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